

AP PHOTO/THEMBA HATEBE



cricket's most level-laying field.

One of the biggest criticisms of the T20 format was how much it was skewed against the bowler. Irfan Pathan, man of the match in the final, said speed was vital, not of the body but the mind. "You have to assess the pitch and the batsman very fast, think very quickly. You can't take one or two overs to settle down; you have to do that in one or two balls." Captains have to think about changing the field after every over, use bowlers sometimes in single-over spells. Former England captain Nasser Hussain says, "Captains are winging it as far as field placements go, but where you have to be cunning is with the batting order, be flexible, get lots of guys sitting in the dugout with their pads on."

In hosting the World T20, South Africa put up a tamasha for two weeks running that would be the envy of Bollywood. Rockets taking off from the scoreboard every time a six was hit, stage smoke curling into the air, and lights flashing around the platform that held the dancing cheerleaders. It couldn't have been amped up higher—local DJ Dr Beat was introduced as a "groovalicious performer" and the "King of Soul and the Professor of Rhythm" all in the same sentence. No

wonder even sober, well-behaved blond Afrikaaner boys couldn't keep sitting when *Mundiyan to bach ke* sounded over the public address system and launched into bhangra alongside 250 Nokia dealers from India.

When BCCI stages its new 20-over IPL early next year, aiming to become cricket's first-ever franchise-driven system, this is what it will be competing against. Even at the domestic level, T20 cannot be played in front of empty stands or make for lacklustre, indifferent television, as was the case when BCCI's first dismal national Twenty20 championship was held last season. Just like ICC needed the World Twenty20 to succeed after the sham-bolic 2007 World Cup, BCCI will need IPL and its spin off, the Champions Twenty20 league, among top domestic sides in the world, to put T20 on the course it would like it to take. Anything

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◀ IAN CHAPPELL, FORMER PLAYER

ARMED TO WATCH: Excited crowds proved T20 was a huge success
else will be anarchy.

The evolution of T20 now will depend on whether the game can tap into what the format does not naturally lend itself to—balance. Former South African Board president Ali Bacher said the T20 game needed to serve as an appetiser in a cricket season, either being played before or after a major series between countries. If there is too much of Twenty20 spread over a long period, "it will lose its appeal".

Others like former Australian coach John Buchanan and former captain Ian Chappell believe the best of Twenty20 can sharpen certain skills which will have a positive impact on both ODI and Test cricket. Says Chappell: "The administrators need to use the game wisely. It should be fitted into the system wisely. The game is always going to keep evolving, revitalising itself; if it doesn't, it will die."

England cricketer Jeremy Snape likened captaincy in T20 cricket to "taking a Lamborghini down a giant slalom course". Today it is as if the Lamborghini is standing at the top of the slalom run, its engines roaring, a powerful beast waiting for someone to hit the gas pedal. ■